

BLACKHOLE
IN
THE GARDEN



BLACKHOLE IN THE GARDEN

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I

I pick up the phone to the panicked voice of a woman, confused and disjointed speech about someone impossible to find. I sit up in my bed, I try to calm her down, get her to focus while I try to get some light in this room, then sitting at my desk. She takes a deep breath, and finally she makes intelligible sentences.

She's Maria, a retiree and a heavy smoker from her raspy voice apparently. She tells me her good friend Jasmine gave her my number after I investigated her husband a few years ago. She's calling me because the young man that is renting her room in her apartment hasn't shown himself in three days. That's not like him she tells me, he's a very routine guy, it's not like him to go for a few days, and even if he did, he'd tell her, and he would've at least come back home to get some of his stuff.

I try to explain to her that it is not really my job to look for missing people, and that the police has a whole department

for this purpose. She then proceeds to explain to me that she has tried to report his disappearance to the police, but that they wouldn't hear anything about it, that he isn't important to look into, that nowadays they don't investigate for stuff that isn't at least a little bit profitable. She isn't wrong on that point, I've had many jobs lately for that precise reason, ever since the police departments have been privatized, people have been forced to seek justice themselves, to call in arms to solve their problems, or call me to put light on some events. Now I'm afraid that more and more I'll be receiving calls just like this one, to investigate kidnappings, vanishings and disappearances.

I scribble her address and tell her that I'll be over at her place for lunch. I hang up the phone, sit back and look at the ceiling, wondering. Wouldn't it be nice sometimes to just disappear, vanish, leave everything behind and run away. I certainly thought about it, however, I wouldn't leave in the middle of the day, unprepared, I'd need to put things in order before I go. I went on, cleaning my place, cleaning myself as I think about what could've happened to a young guy to disappear so suddenly. A fight, a dispute, a vengeance. An accident, a murder, an abduction. I find my vape between two sofa cushions, my breakfast for the soul.

I'm late for my morning appointment with an attorney regarding a previous case, I have time to put some water on my face, throw on a probably clean yellowish shirt, comb my unruly hair, but I have no time to shave. I leave my stuffy studio and start walking downtown towards the courthouse. I need to sign the testimony I gave to the police before a case goes in

front of the judge, a case about an associate who embezzled a lot of money from the company he had with his partner. The partner suspected something, so he called me to discreetly look into it and find evidence that he was really embezzling. I'm a good private investigator; when you have good contacts, and know some loopholes and cracks in the system, it's easier to find the careless mistakes newbies make when they try and be smarter than everybody else. B

ut the bureaucracy following a case is always the worse part. The sky is white, entirely covered in a thin cloud veil, smothering the city, locking the damp air low. I'm walking fast, sweating in my coat. The courthouse, immense building, heavy, looking like a Greek temple if temple were scary, inspiring nothing but fear, like the Gods weren't on your side. I spot the attorney pacing along the large white stairs leading to the entrance. He face lit up with relief when he sees me approaching, holding a pile of papers before he even says good morning. I bend over to sign the papers as clean as I can given the position and lack of flat surface to do this. I don't really have time to read the transcription that I'm signing, but I trust him to not have fabricated anything, and not to have changed my words.

Hopefully I won't have to testify either, wasting precious hours, spent waiting and sitting. He gets the papers back, thanks me, gives me a smile and rushes back inside. I'm left shivering in front of the building, but nothing makes me want to linger here. Checking the time, I'm now on time to get to the lady's house for lunch. Hands in my pockets, I take my sweet time to go across town, vaping softly along the way,

adding fragrant fog to the dropping clouds. I walk a shadow-less day in the city, looking at people passing and walking, guessing their secrets. Too much cologne to be innocent, too many shopping bags to be guilt-free, hiding something behind big sunglasses.

Checking the address sent earlier, I arrive in front of an apartment complex, and ring Ms. Marie F. The door lets me in with a buzzing noise. I skip the elevator, too many accidents in my opinion. Three flights of stairs later, Marie opens her door to her warm living room, it smells a little bit of dust, dried flowers, and onions cooking. She rushes back to the kitchen, and I follow along, offering some help to prepare lunch. Marie seems to be well into her seventies, not perfectly mobile, but lively. She obviously categorically refuses any help in the kitchen, and the table is already set up for two on the small kitchen table, overlooking the calm street. I sit down on the Formica chair that's about twice my age and listen to the old lady tell me about her day and what she is cooking, asking me if I like carrot pie.

Even if I didn't, I would never dare to oppose her, she seems very opinionated and I wouldn't want to upset her over food. I feel like Marie is of that generation of women for whom the house, particularly the kitchen is her realm, and no opposition is tolerated. She puts the tart in the oven, takes a bottle of red wine from a cabinet and orders me to open it up, so we can have a drink and chat while the pie cooks.

I follow the order, opening the bottle and pouring two generous glasses. She tells me to start without her as the phone rings in the living room. I wait for her for a few minutes,

looking around in the kitchen. It is exactly what I was expecting her kitchen to look like, straight out of a 70's magazine, everything covered in either dust or just wears and tears. After a moment, I decide to take my glass and walk around the apartment.

I hear Marie in the living room in what appears to be a very lively discussion about some friend of hers, gossips. I follow the corridor a bit further, sipping the rich wine. Bathroom, a closet, Marie's room, and then the young man's room, at the end of the carpeted corridor. The door is already cracked open. I let myself in. The room is a mix between the furniture from several decades ago, and the energy of young man living in it. The bed is made with navy blue sheets, suggesting a young male sleeping here.

There's the classic chair covered in probably half-clean half-dirty clothes. The desk is covered in different papers and envelopes, his computer open, black screen. I check to see if he's still logged in, to no avail. The papers go from bank notices to personal epistolary conversations, handwritten, how old school. Most of them are written in the same tight-knit handwriting, signed with a B. They talk about nothing specific; judging by their lack of depth, they could very well have been postcard messages.

One has a different handwriting, seeing that it is unfinished, I assume that it is his, and that he hadn't had time to finish it. In the distance I hear Marie hanging up the phone, I then innocently go back to the kitchen, and sit back down at the table, my glass of wine already half empty.

Marie sits down in front of me, excusing herself for the interruption, and that she kind of forgot that I was here while being in her conversation with her friend. She explains to me that she's forgetting more and more lately and is hoping that this is just old age, and not some illness. She is sipping carefully her wine, analyzing my face. I ask her to tell me the story from the start, so I can get a better idea with what I'm dealing with. So, she starts to tell me about David, the 24-year-old who rents her room.

He's been living with her for the past year after answering an ad for a room. She was initially targeting students, for her to have some company and offer cheap accommodation. Her children couldn't come to see her, and look after her as often as before, and with her husband gone for a few years now, it was also safer for her to have a young soul living with her. She liked him right away, very polite, clean, he smelled like mimosa.

He's an employee of one of the big companies in the city, and from what she understands he's riddled with debts, mostly student loans paybacks, that explains the fact that he's renting a small room. He comes back home every evening after work, rarely goes out, keeps to himself a lot. They usually have dinner together, chat about the day over food, he would then go to his room and spend a few hours there, the light on, never making loud noises.

Marie takes the pie out of the oven, the fragrant smell of carrot now floating in the kitchen. She cuts two big slices and disposes them on the plates. I ask her about his social life, if she knows some of his friends, but it would appear that he never brought anyone home. She confides that she has the

impression that he would sometimes leave in the middle of the night and come home before the sun rises, but she never really checked, you know after having kids, mothers develop a certain sixth sense with these sorts of things. I take rapid notes on a small pocket notepad, to be sure not to forget some details.

What about his parents? He avoided this subject, but from what she gathered, they're either dead or they just haven't talked in a very long time, she had no way of contacting them, she couldn't find a number or an address. As I'm eating, I realize how hungry I've been, and I feel clarity falling upon me as I eat. I can think more clearly now. I ponder as I eat and as Marie talks about David, how unlikely it is that he wouldn't come home with laundry still in the washer, with his personal computer still here, and without telling her. I think he reminded her of her late husband, she doesn't seem to have that motherly protectiveness towards him, but rather real affection, like a friend. Lunch over, Marie, the good host that she is starts to pile the dishes. I ask her if I could visit David's room before I leave.

She leads me to the room I've been earlier. She leaves me here, going back to her kitchen, dragging her pink slippers on the floor. Being free to look around and dig deeper, I close the door behind me. I take out my small electronic camera and start taking pictures of the room, the desk, and the clothes. I check the wardrobe, everything seems to be here, barely a couple of hangers empty, probably what he was wearing when he disappeared.

I check his bedside table drawer, nothing out of the ordinary, regular boy stuff. I go back to his desk, detailing a bit more what I saw earlier, digging through the letters. The one he stopped writing in the middle of mentions a garden, saying that it never looked better than it does now. A half drunk tea-cup is sitting on his desk, green tea with a flower, jasmine maybe judging by the smell.

His desk drawer was hiding a portable music player, turning it on reveals that the last song he was listening to was Brahms requiem. The idea of suicide lingering. His bookshelves had a lot of history books, some classical literature and some more scientific books, biology, physics. I check the one with the least amount of dust, and it appears to be a Greek mythology book about the Hesperides.

Nothing hidden inside, no annotations but a cornered page on a photo of a Greek illustration on vase of the Hesperides. The lack of anything truly personal in his room makes me wonder, no pictures, no posters, no traces of loved ones. I notice under his bed the corner of a sort of notebook. I take it out from under the bed, sit on his bed and start to look into it. Mostly poetry, the boy was writing poetry, nothing too gloomy, love poems, poems about not belonging, poems about living free.

There is a picture of him wearing his diploma attire on the wall behind the door, I take a picture of him to show around. He's smiling, but no one is posing with him. I take some more pictures, but the room, apart from the decor, is pretty bare, not much to look for.

I go back to Marie sipping tea in the living room. She looks a bit confused at first, like she doesn't remember who I am, but she sits back down with a smile, asking if I could find something useful. To be honest, not really but we never know. I ask her about his work, what did he do exactly, and where is located the company he works for. She tells me he works at the headquarters of this big tech company in the outskirts of the city, Blackhole.

Some software company everybody has heard of, but no one can really say what they do precisely. Money laundering for all I know. She stands up and gives me set of keys, the doubles of all of his keys, he was a precocious man. There were five keys and a small hippo figurine on the key-chain. She shows me the keys she knows: the front door and the mailbox. I'll have to find what the other ones are for.

Marie shuffles away to a drawer in her sideboard and takes out a brown envelope. It's half of the payment she tells me, it is a big part of her savings, but he's worth it. I take a look inside, that's several thousand at least, after a quick math, I come to the conclusion that this should be enough if this case doesn't drag for too long, and of no over the top deception is needed for the investigation.

I thank her for her time and assure her that I'm very competent, and that I will do everything that I can to bring her if not David, at least closure. I leave the warm apartment reluctantly. Direction Blackhole headquarters.

II

As the bus rocks me on the way to David's office, I try to put myself into his shoes. If nothing bad has happened to him, which I still have no idea, what is the most likely chain of events. He seemed to be dreaming of a better world, does that mean that he was deeply unhappy.

Did he find this missing happiness and follow it? Or he did not find it and decided to take his life. He had no friends and family, if he was living for his job, I hope I can find some more clues at his job, maybe some people will know where he might be. This case could be over today, but it could also never be. I'm on the bus David takes every morning to go to work, it is a twenty-five-minute commute, so I try to pay attention on

the way to the shops, the people, the terrain. Something could have caught his eye, tempted him.

Nothing jumps out to me. Twelve stops later, I get down and walk two minutes towards that gigantic concrete building, with the “Blackhole” sign and an aura of pure dread. I’m concerned at the low number of windows apparent for such a big building, housing hundreds if not thousands of employees. As I get closer, I realize that I don’t see a main entrance. I see doors alright, but they seem like service doors.

The building looks huge and going around would take me forever. I get to one of the service doors. There is no door handle but a black pad, and a plaque next to it indicates the services it leads to. From what Marie gathered, he was working in the communication branch. One of the departments indicated on the plaque is “Connecting Relations”, that sounds like communication to me.

I get his keys out, ruling out the two previous ones, one of the three left has one of those built-in reader that I can use on the pad next to the door. A beep and a clack later, the door opens ajar. I let myself in to a simple concrete staircase. This seems very sketchy to me, even though I’ve never worked in a proper office before, I’ve investigated enough bosses and manager to know that this is a bit odd.

I start to climb up the stairs. At the end of each flight of stairs, a door with a plaque indicating which department you’re at. I keep climbing until on the third floor I can read “Connecting Relations” next to the door. This time there is a door handle, and I let myself in.

The door opens to a rather normal-looking office space. Artificial lights, grayish blue carpeting. The furniture looks fairly new. A lot of the desks are empty, and the ones occupied don't pay attention to me. I walk around until I see a name chart conveniently indicating the position of a lot of employees. I check where David's office is located and go in this direction. So far, I think I haven't attracted attention onto me. I see no cameras, so that's a good sign.

The only thing that worries me slightly is that according to the chart, David is sharing his office with someone. This could be either a problem or a blessing. I hear people coming over from the corridor, so I let myself go to the men's bathroom. Seems clean enough. It's the perfect break. I get to the urinal, relieving myself. Halfway through my business someone comes in. Act natural. There're only two urinals so naturally he takes the one next to me.

We give each other a polite nod. An awkward silence sets in. I'm already done peeing, pretending to keep going, and the poor guy is obviously a shy pisser. It seems like an eternity until finally he manages to squeeze out something. After a minute or so, I'm still pretending to focus, the guy finally gets his pants back on and leaves. I get my pants back on and go look myself in the mirror as I wash my hands. I look a bit tired but I think that I look sad enough to go unnoticed in this building. I get my ear on the door.

No one. I leave the room and get back on track to find David's desk. This place feels so unnatural and maze-like. I truly wonder what is everybody doing behind their computers here. I

haven't seen a head office either, nor heard a manager give out orders. I eventually find the door with David's name tag with the job description "Key Relations Coordinator".

Underneath his, the name Judy is written, with the same job description. I knock and let myself in. There's nobody in here. The two desks face each other, and they look rather personalized, I'm quite surprised. It is not very difficult to tell who's desk is who's, considering that Judy's has pictures of a cat and what appears to be a husband.

She looks sweet, young. I sit down at David's desk. I turn his computer on. While the machine boots up, I look around his desk. He has some small animal figurines on his desk, sort of like the one on his key-chain. Here too he has a teacup with a bottom left of cold tea. Piles of paper, all work related. Lists of names, letters from other departments. Another notebook here, but nothing interesting in here, apart from some doodles in the margins. He has two plants however, a big-leafed Ficus and a medium-sized succulent.

They're very well kept, a real plant lover. In the drawers, some snacks, some stationary, but one pen stands out. Everything is branded Blackhole, but one pen is bright red with the word "Velvet" written on it. I put the pen in my pocket. The paper basket has some paper in it, so I check it out. Nothing important except maybe for a post-it note on which the word "Greenwood St" is written. Odd or maybe not.

As I try to log into the computer, the door opens. The young lady that I saw on the photo came into the office, so that must be Judy. She gets startled seeing me. She thought for a second

that I was David, then asks me who I am and why I'm here. I stand up and extend my hand, introducing myself as a private investigator looking into David's alleged disappearance. She seems to relax, but is surprised by the term "disappearance", she thought that David was just sick, or that he had gone on break somewhere. I ask her if she knows him well, if she has heard from him, or if she knows where he went.

Apparently not, because to her, he took some personal time off. I keep casually interrogating her, she seems very chatty and friendly. I ask her if they were friends or just work colleague, and if she knows about his friends. He went to her house a couple times and had some drinks; they are good buddies and have fun at work the two of them. By the way, what is it that you do here exactly?

They manage the relations and liaisons between clients and the company, as well as the relations within the departments inside the company. I take some quick notes in my notebook. I ask her if he has any friends that she knows of, any people that I could talk to. She sends me back to Marie, but other than that, here it's always been the two of them. I ask her if they've ever been romantically involved, but as she was laughing out loud before I could even finish my sentence.

I take it as a no. She adds that David prefers the company of the men, but he's always been very discreet about it, he doesn't want it to become a problem for him here, and in his life in general. Now that's a new development, a new angle on this story. I ask her if she knows of any romantic partners that he might have had in the past, but once again she's in the dark about that.

I ask her if anything out of the ordinary happened at work recently, something that would have scared him, but no, nothing. They have very few direct contacts with their superiors and colleagues, nothing ever happens here. I don't have a strong lead to follow at this moment. Before I go, I ask her about the Greenwood St, that doesn't ring a bell, but the red Velvet pen does. It's the underground secret gay bar of the town, it's invitation only.

Part club part bar, people down there want to have fun and be among themselves. But I could go ask Greg, a guy on this floor who's always kind of desperate to get there with a date, it's worth a shot. With the lack of leads to follow, I don't really have a choice here. Before I leave, I ask her if she can unlock his computer to see if maybe he has left some clues as to where he went, or something that could point in a direction.

Judy agrees, telling me that his password is rather easy to remember, it's his favorite flower and his birth year. The computer greets me with a picture of a green hill. Judy keeps an eye over my shoulder as I start to look around the very organized folders. A lot of Excel sheets, unread emails and filled out PDFs. In his browser, one of the tabs is a map of the Greenwood St, a small street outside of town, with absolutely nothing around. Apart from this, nothing really interesting or that jumps out to me. I turn off the computer and pull away from the desk, leaving.

She gives me directions to see Greg, and I thank her for her time. I do leave her my phone number, in case something comes up on her side, a memory or just anything that could

help me. Now Greg. I try to follow the direction given, but it's not that easy to follow in this office space. I spot a brunette head in the semi-open space, as I get closer,

I realize that it's the guy I shared an awkward piss earlier. He looks up at me, mildly surprised, asking me what I need him for. I hesitate for a minute to go undercover, to pretend to hit on him to get an invite or something, but I feel like a gay guy would see right through my act without difficulty. I decide to play honest cards and introduce myself the same way I did for Judy. But before I ask him for an invitation, I ask him a bit about David.

He knows him a bit, they've seen each other around. At the Velvet. Sure, at the Velvet, Greg has been going for a while, and David has been almost a regular for the past couple months. You could easily see him hanging there every Friday night, he'd probably be here tonight. I tell him that no one had seen him in three days, which surprised him, because David appears to be a pretty regular guy, not the kind to disappear like this. I ask him if he knows any of the guys he was seeing there. He knows their faces, not so much their names.

That's the perfect transition to ask him to get me inside the bar. I tell him that I need to go, maybe we could go together tonight, he can show me the guys he's been hanging out with. Greg sits back in his chair, thinks for a second, then makes his offer: he agrees to take me there on the condition that I wear the outfit that he'll bring me tonight.

Too happy to get a way in, I accept the terms. Greg will come by my house tonight to drive us there around eleven. Seems good enough to me, I look forward to it. He flashes me a smile, then goes back to work. See you later. I can finally leave this forsaken building. I find my way back, not without confusion about the layout.

When finally, the fresh air of the outside hits my face, I realize that much like casinos, this place of constant artificial light skews your perception of time.

Time to go back home, write down a report on my day, to clear out a bit what happened and where I'm going next. I look up at the few stars appearing in the early evening sky. The clouds have lifted, the air is fresh, and I feel confident for the night to come.

III

Laying in my apartment, vaping on the couch while I wait for Greg to come pick me up. I took a shower earlier, then went to my desk to write down everything I've learned today. The leads are thin, I hope I'll find more tonight. I'm dosing off, slowly drifting into sleep.

Quarter past eleven, my phone rings. I sit up, jolted awake. I pick up the phone, Greg's voice on the other side telling me he'll be here in 5 minutes. I brace myself, take a last look at myself in the mirror before leaving. I get inside his car waiting right in front of my building.

He put a musky oud-y fragrance; it suits him. He's wearing a sheer black shirt with what appears to be a leather short, letting his long legs bare. That's almost a caricature of the gay

look to me, but it suits him, he has a nice build, so that's only fair to flaunt his best features. We chat a bit during the ride, he tells me about the bag of clothes in the back, waiting to be worn by me. I'm dreading this a bit, but I'm sure that tonight is going to be fun. After a ten minutes' drive, he parks in the parking lot in front of a normal looking neighborhood, a bunch a apartment complexes not so different from mine.

We leave the car, and he opens up the trunk where my outfit is waiting for me. He pulls out a pair of bootlegged pleather pants with a lace-up fly, a mesh top with a pleather vest matching the pants. I stare at it for a minute, Greg smirking next to me. He forgot to mention that tonight is a "Kinky Leather x Latex" night special.

I undress in the parking lot, and squeeze myself in the outfit. I've never felt more naked wearing something. He says I look like a straight Marlon Brando, insisting that I keep my sullen look to stay mysterious. The both of us walk towards one of the buildings. I'm skeptical, this might be a farce. There isn't anybody in the parking lot, and I can't hear anything nearby. We take the stairs leading to the basement of the building, I still can't hear anything except for the television from the guy on the first floor. We walk a bit in the brightly lit corridors of the basement, until a guy leaning against a door appears at the end of the corridor.

He's wearing all black, straightens when he sees us coming towards him. He seems to recognize Greg, but still asks him for an invitation. Greg pulls out a small pink card, telling the bouncer that I'm his plus-one for the night. A nod later and

we're inside the airlock, the music clearly distinguishable here. The next door opens to a club, dark, electro music playing, smelling of sweat, cheap vodka and too much cologne. Greg motions me to the bar.

The place isn't huge, but there's at least fifty people for the moment. Some dancing, some hanging on the small couches, and most just standing drinking and chatting loudly over the music. Greg grabs us two vodka tonic and we start to move around. I need him to point to me the guys that are, or were close one way or another to David. Everybody is on theme, wearing some sort of leather or latex, some take it very seriously, head to toe in latex bodysuit, others might just be wearing a leather cap. Even as a straight man I could feel the sexual and sensual tension in the air of the club. As we wander around the club in search of a place to sit,

I look around at people in the club, but it seems that the club is also looking at me. It all seems very strange to me, I'm not used to being watched this closely, I am usually the one looking at people intensely. We find a padded bench to sit on. Drink in hand, Greg starts to point to me the guys he knows, and the ones he has seen talk to David.

There aren't that many for the moment. Right now, Greg can confidently point me to three different men. The first one is a guy named Roy, tall guy wearing denim and leather by the bar. He seems to be waiting for someone, so this is the perfect opportunity for me.

I take a sip of liquid courage and head to him. I decide to keep my mysterious sullen look to approach him. I'm trying to keep some sort of professionalism as I introduce myself. He looks me up and down and introduces himself reluctantly. I offer to buy him a drink, and that seems to loosen him up.

I tell him that I'm not just here for his eyes, I'm investigating a guy named David. He panics to the idea that I might be police undercover. I reassure him, I'm just a PI, I just want to know if he knows him. The name doesn't ring a bell, neither does the picture. I thank him, but now his attitude has changed. As I shake his hand, I read in his eyes something like lust, now that he knows I'm not a hunter, I feel like he views me as a challenge. I leave him there, going back to Greg.

I see him in the distance still on the bench, but he seems to be in the company of a big guy talking in his ear something that must be really funny. Not a problem, the second guy he pointed me out is still there. He's on the dance floor, dancing under the lights. I get close to him, it's gonna be hard to try and talk, so I just dance my way to him.

He reacts positively to my presence. I dance with him for a couple of minutes, until I motion him to go to a quieter place. He follows me a bit further away from the flashing lights and music, where it was quiet enough to have a conversation. He asks me for my name, introducing himself as Ben.

I apologize in advance for ruining his potential interest and then introduce myself and why I wanted to talk to him. He does recognize David in the picture, they have talked before a few times, but it never really went beyond anything but

drinks. He knows a guy that knows him a little bit more than him. A certain Gino, and that happens to be the third guy Greg told me about.

I thank him extending a hand, but he reach out to hug me, telling me that if I have anymore questions, he would be available. He leaves me with a wink. I look around the club to see if I can spot Gino. I saw him earlier talking with a group of guys. He wasn't wearing a lot, a leather brief with a leather harness. I can't see him right now so I'm going back to see if Greg has seen him.

The guy that was with him earlier is gone. I sit back down next to him, and tell him that my investigation isn't going very well right now. I ask him if he has seen Gino since earlier. He shakes his head, but tells me that he could be in the bathroom. I imagine that in this club, the bathroom is hardly a place to pee, but that a whole other kind of night is happening there. I guess I'm going to have to go if I don't want to wait here forever.

I spot the restrooms, and shimmy my way there, trying to avoid the crowd of aggressively dancing horny guys. I follow the dark corridor to a place that smells more and more like urine. So I guess some people do pee here. There's obviously only one gender bathroom, a large room with half a dozen urinals and as many stalls. It's dark and crowded even here. My eyes slowly getting accustomed to the lighting, I start to see slightly better what is going on.

Oral sex in plain sight, the couple at the end might even be going at it. Urinals, like I had imagined, are just a pretext for guys to masturbate together. All the stalls seem occupied, with a small line of people waiting and cruising behind. I look around but I can't see Gino here. Two guys exit one of the stalls, and from here I can see that they might have been in there for the gloryhole.

A group of guys got tired of waiting for a stall to free itself, so they start to do their lines of whatever it is in plain sight near the sinks. I try to make myself discreet as I embrace the room with a sight. It is a very lively crowd, and even with all the gloom and decadence and sex, I still like this club, and it is such an exhilarating thing to be able to infiltrate it. I knew of places like this of course, but being able to experience it leaves me amazed.

After a few minutes, my back against the cold wall of the bathroom, I see Gino leaving a stall, eyes darting left and right, smiling with his white teeth. He goes to run some cold water on his face before starting to exit. I follow behind him and call him in the corridor. Now it's just the two of us in the dark corridor, one way the club noises echoing over us, and the other way the bathroom clatter still agitated. He asks me if he knows me. For the third time of the night, and hopefully the last, I introduce myself.

He nods along as I speak, when I'm done, he smiles. He tells me I worry too much. He knows David a bit yes, they've hung out before. He might even know where he is now. I ask him what he knows exactly, it might be a life-or-death situation. He laughs it off, laughing at how dramatic I am. He tells me

to drop it off, everything should be alright. I run after him as he starts to walk away. I tell him that if he knows anything it is his duty as a citizen to help. He insists that David is probably fine. He knows something, this is certain.

I try to think about everything that I've learned so far, which isn't much. I must have missed something. There was this note on Greenwood Street, this empty trail outside the city. I was planning on going next if nothing turned up tonight, but maybe Gino knows something about it. I rush back into the club, looking frantically around for the hunk in a leather speedo. He left me twenty seconds ago, but that didn't stop him from kissing some dude in a dark corner.

I run back to him, interrupting their very sensual moment. Now he doesn't seem amused, but rather annoyed at my insistence. I ask him point blank about Greenwood Street. And there it is, the reaction I've been expecting all night, a glint in his eyes, proving he knows something about this whole thing. He asks the guy to leave us, pushing him a slap on the derriere. He asks me about the street, asking me what I know about it.

His attitude has completely changed, he's frowning, almost scary if he wasn't dressed the way he was. I tell him about the post-it note found in David's bin, but that I don't know anything more than that. He steps back a bit and ponders. He knows I'm persistent and that I won't give it a rest until I've been to the bottom of the story. He tells me he can take me to Greenwood, tomorrow morning.

However, going there is complicated. Either I go and see the whole thing, but then I can't come back. Or I go there just to see David for a moment, and then leave, without seeing more than the gate. I can decide tomorrow morning, but these are the terms. We exchange our information, he tells me he'll be at my door tomorrow at ten, he'll wait five minutes, then he's gone, with or without me. I nod and thank him with a hug. We part way, relieved, him to go back to his partying, me to finally have answers.

I look for Greg who's no longer on the bench. He's dancing with some big hairy guy. I go behind him and tell him in his ear that I found what I wanted. He stops his dance, and walks me back to his car. Leaving the club into the brightly lit corridors of the basement is a harsh return to reality. I realize that for some reason I'm covered in sparkles. Greg asks me what I found in the bathroom of the club for me to be so happy and free to go back home. I finally have a strong lead, and it's pointing out to be a good outcome for David. We go back to the trunk of his car so I can get back into my civilian clothes. Now this is a second harsh return to reality, shedding my skin that made me feel so naked to begin with, but that made me feel so much more confident in there.

Now I'm just another guy, a random person in the streets. I thank Greg, he can go back to the club, I don't need a ride home, I'll walk under the stars. He asks me to keep him posted on the investigation. I watch him go back inside. I somehow spent two hours there, it felt like a flash. I start to walk back home, alone with the sky, heavy with stars.

IV

Now the sun finally rises. I couldn't sleep last night after going home. I've been pacing around. Now I'm lying down on my couch, waiting for it to be ten. I'm very curious about this whole deal. Gino was particularly suspicious last night. I still can't figure out what this whole thing is about. Why the secrecy. I'm afraid it might be a cult or something. Everything is so sketchy, but I have no other lead.

I don't want to go and find him hung by the feet in some wood shack, his throat slit. I've been thinking like this all night, thinking of all the possibilities. And I keep going back to the two-choice proposition. What does it mean to leave it all behind. Was it serious? It's time now, and my night long

pondering hasn't helped me. I take my stuff and leave my apartment. Like he had said he would, Gino is waiting for me at ten sharp in his blue car. I get inside the car, passenger seat. He's wearing a simple black t-shirt with denim pants. He still looks like a big guy; I think he's got the arms to pick up a dead body of my weight.

I think the lack of sleep is making me a little bit paranoid. Anyhow, he seems very focused. He asks me if I still want to do it, asks me if I chose, between leaving it all behind or just a peek. We're leaving town, the green hills going by through the window. I tell him that I don't know, I just want to talk and see David, to have an explanation, to get to the bottom of this. We drive for a while, the landscape alternating between woods and hilly plains.

I spot some rabbits, some deer with their kids. It is a lovely drive, if it wasn't for such a stressful situation. We pass a small town, a village. So far, we haven't seen a lot of cars on the road, and this village is rather desert. Gino is a good driver, and despite his focused eyes, he is a lovely conversationalist. He tells me about his night, all the guys he hooked up with. When I approached him last night, he thought for a second that I was hitting on him, now he's telling me that he would have eaten me up like candy, a shark smile on the lips. He signals me that we're getting closer.

At some point he turns on a small dirt road. A street sign indicates "Greenwood St". A trail dividing a forest in two. We ride the bumpy way for what feels forever, until eventually we reach a stop, a wooden barrier in the middle of the road, the woods on both sides. There is a glade beyond the gate, but the

tire marks stop here. Gino turns off the engine and looks at me very seriously. We exit the car. The air is cool, there is no noise, just the wind rustling the leaves of the trees, some birds in the distance.

I follow Gino going beyond the wooden barrier, into the open glade. Lush grass welcomes on the grass. We cross the field, the grass going up to my knee. After the night I had, this feels so calming, so pure. I follow him into the woods. The tall trees like a canopy above us. It's a mix of oak trees, birch trees and maybe some elms.

Under the trees a thick carpet of dead leaves and moss soften our steps. Gino stops in front of a big tree, his stump large and stout. He turns and looks at me. Now it's time to choose. Keep going with him and never go back, or just wait here until he brings David along. I look at him straight in the eyes. I think for a second.

But I'm not ready. I tell him I'll wait here. He tells me to sit at the roots of the tree and wait for him. If I try to follow him, I'll be stuck with him there. I sit down and wait. Gino disappears behind the tree; I listen to him walk for a moment until I hear nothing. I wait for him here, sitting in utter silence, listening to the woods, the calm.

After a moment, I hear steps again. I stand up and listen. I hope it's just Gino coming back with David. And thankfully it is just that. Behind Gino, a young guy wearing overalls, he looks healthy, he looks happy. He has dirty hands, like he had been working in a garden. I introduce myself, explaining that

Marie is the one sending me to look for him. He is a bit embarrassed, he was afraid that something like this could happen. He explains to me that he found himself coming here, and too tempted to go and see, found himself stuck wherever he was before. He takes out a pile of papers from his pocket. It's a pile of letters destined for all the people he left behind without being able to say goodbye. I take them and assure him that they will be passed along.

I ask him if I can take a picture of him, one last picture to show people that he is safe. He turns to Gino, who nods. I snap a quick pic of him smiling, waving at the camera. Before he leaves, I ask him if it was worth it, to leave it all behind. He smiles and tells me that yes, yes it absolutely was. The two boys go back to wherever they were, and I sat back down. I don't know what I'm going to tell his friends and colleagues. At least, he is alive and well. I do believe he was sincere. A while later Gino comes back, we can finally go back

EPILOGUE

My bag is waiting for me near the door. I look at my apartment one last time. All my valuables are gone, everything that was dear to my heart is in my bag, or in the storage unit. I've left everything I didn't need behind. I close the door behind me. Gino is waiting for me in his blue car. He smiles when he sees me.

I put my back in the trunk and get in. That's it, that's the moment for me to leave it all behind. I look at the city as the car drives away, I feel at peace with my choice, and I don't leave much behind. It has barely been a month since I went to see David. Marie and Judy were relieved to know he was fine; however they were a bit confused as to why and how this hap-

pened. But in the end, they were happy for him if he is happy. And that made me think about my life, about what I want.

I have nothing here; I spend my life chasing ghosts and mysteries. I think I came to a point where I needed a major change, or else I'd be stuck in my routine for a long time. I want what David is having, whatever it might be. I felt connected to him through his life, so little attaches, hardly anybody left behind. I could do that. That's why I called Gino back, that's why I asked him to drive me back to Greenwood street, this time for good.

As the car takes me away from my life, I feel lighter. I stay contemplative as the hills pass by, until the final bend, the last street, Greenwood. We're back at the wooden gate. It's cloudy today, a strong wind blowing away.

We cross the meadow, and I follow Gino past the big oak, deeper into the woods.

